From a Pile of Ideas to One Shared Page

An unhurried plan for getting ready with Mom: ten actions in order, with the dates left for you to fill in.

The goal: one page the whole family has seen, with everyone's ideas sorted into what's worth doing now, what you're deliberately waiting on, and the questions still open. It can take a month or a season.

Put a name next to an action only when that person has said yes, and tick it when it's done. The “by when” column is there if a date helps you; leave it empty if it doesn't.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Ask Mom what she'd like to get ready and what she'd rather leave alone. Write down what she says.			
2. Collect every idea anyone in the family has had, including the ones you think are too early, on one list.			
3. Put what you already have in one place: appointment notes Mom has shared, what you've written about her days, and the questions still open.			
4. Go down the list and mark each item “task” or “decision.” A task is something someone does. A decision would commit Mom to something.			
5. Sort the list into three: worth doing now, deliberately waiting, and needs a conversation first.			
6. Beside each question the family can't answer, write who it would go to: Mom, her doctor or a care consultant.			
7. Break each “worth doing now” item into pieces someone could do in an afternoon.			
8. Show the pieces to the family and ask which one each person would be willing to take. Write down offers only, and notice how many pieces have ended up with one person, yourself included.			
9. Ask Mom who she is happy to have see the page, and share it with them.			
10. Write a day at the bottom of the page to look at it again.			

You're done when

There is one page the family has seen. It tells apart what's worth doing now from what you're deliberately waiting on, each open question has a note of who it goes to, the offers of help are written beside the pieces people chose, and there's a day at the bottom to look again. What comes after that, settling who looks after each part and who stands in for them, agreeing which changes would bring the plan back out, and a professional's review of the order, isn't on this list, because it isn't the family's to do alone.

Along the way

- A gap can stay a gap. “Nobody knows yet” is a complete entry.
- If a relative would rather not take part for now, leave their line empty. They can still read the page, if Mom is happy for them to see it.
- If two people would sort the same item differently, write it under “needs a conversation first” and move on.
- Keep the waiting items worded as things the family has chosen to wait on, not things it has ruled out.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes the family's part. It doesn't choose or compare places for Mom to live, set a date for anything to change, or confirm that anything on the page is right for her health. Finishing it doesn't stand in for the professional review it prepares you for.

Ready for the next step?

You've taken a pile of ideas to one page the family has seen. The care interview adds the other half: it goes through Mom's situation as it is today with you, area by area, so there is a clear starting point to look back at later, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›